Don't blame me, fear made me crazy: How fear of crime shapes victim blaming

THE UNIVERSITY of NORTH CAROLINA at CHAPEL HILL

Helen Devine & Kurt Gray

Deepest Beliefs Lab

INTRO

- Victim blaming is when a target of a crime is considered at fault for their victimhood.
- We would expect those who worry more about being a victim would place more blame on perpetrators of crime.
- However, many react to reports of crime by sharing the steps they take to prevent the crime happening to them. →
  - We were curious if increased personal fear of crime = more victim blaming attitudes.

OBJECTIVE

Examine if those who **fear crime are more likely to victim blame.**

METHOD

- N = 158 (M_{age} = 35.3, SD_{age} = 10.7)
  - 47.5% female, 50.6% male, 1.9% NB
- Participants read four vignettes where a crime had taken place.
- Measures:
  - Perceptions of both the perpetrator and target for each crime.
  - 3 face-valid items for victim blaming attitudes.
  - 10-item Fear of Crime scale (*Etopio & Berthelot, 2022*).

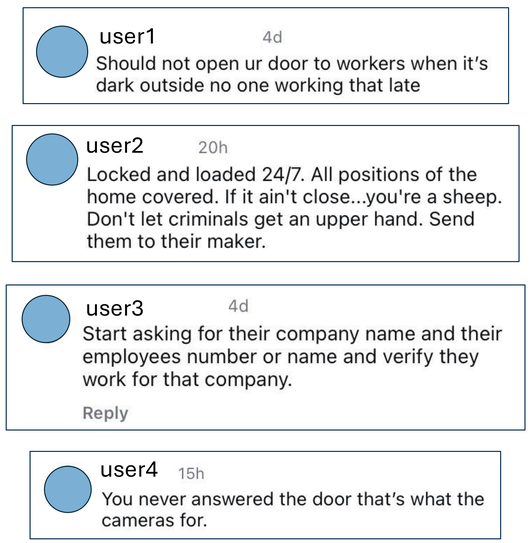
Vignettes varied by severity/consequence and proximity between perp. and target.

		Severity: High	Severity: Low
Proximity	High	Physical assault	Mugging
Proximity	Low	Breaking & entering	Pickpocketing

Why do we react to these news stories...

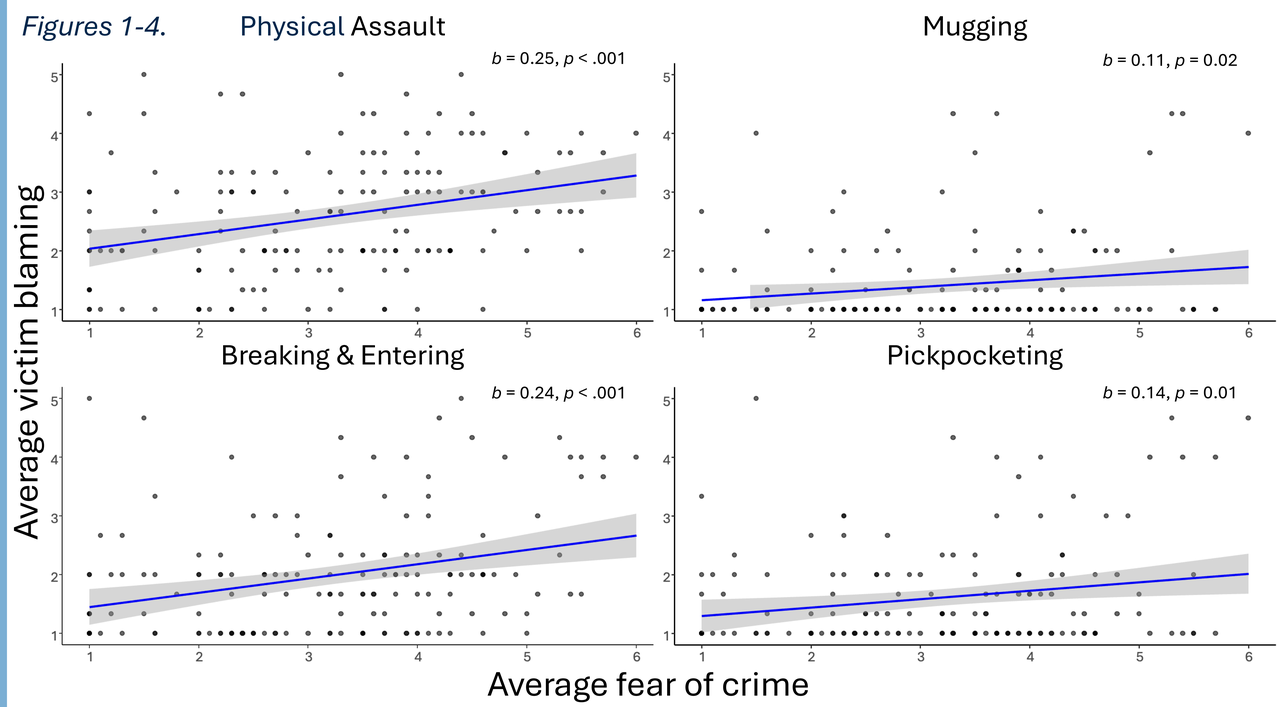


...like this?



Victim blaming may be a self-protective strategy for those who see themselves as a potential target of crime

Figures 1-4.



RESULTS

- Fear of crime was significantly correlated with victim blaming across all vignettes (*Table 1*).

Table 1.
Correlations between fear of crime and victim blaming for different crimes

Variable	1	2	3	4	5
1. Fear of crime	—				
2. Physical assault	0.31**	—			
3. Mugging	0.18*	0.38**	—		
4. Breaking & entering	0.30**	0.51**	0.48**	—	
5. Pickpocketing	0.20*	0.36**	0.67**	0.60**	—

*p < .05. **p < .01.

- **Fear of crime significantly predicted victim blaming attitudes** for all four crimes (*Figures 1-4*).
  - The effect was stronger for high severity crimes (assault and breaking & entering).

DISCUSSION

- Findings suggest that those who fear being a target of a crime are more likely to place blame on victims of crime.
- Victim blaming may serve to reduce cognitive dissonance and provide a sense of control over potential victimhood.
  - I.e., "If they did XYZ like I would, they wouldn't have been a victim!"
- Future work should examine if **limiting fear-based crime messaging** (e.g. true crime podcasts) can help **reduce victim blaming attitudes.**

CONTACT:

devineh@unc.edu
@helenldevine
helendevine.owlstown.net